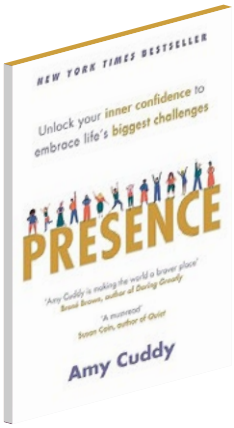
Presence
by Amy Cuddy

Reading Time:
10 minutes



What if the biggest shift in your performance came not from new tactics, but from showing up as your truest self—especially under pressure? Presence is about accessing personal power in high-stakes moments so your words, body, and values align. Amy Cuddy's core idea is simple and practical: small "self-nudges" in posture, breath, and mindset can quiet anxiety, reduce impostorism, and make room for real connection and impact. Presence isn't permanent or performative; it's a moment-to-moment ability to express your true thoughts, feelings, values, and potential.

"We convince by our presence." —Walt Whitman

About the book

With more than 500,000 copies sold since its 2015 release, *Presence* by Amy Cuddy builds on her research into body language, confidence, and the science of "power posing." Expanding on her TED Talk—one of the most viewed in history—the book shows how small physical shifts can change mindset, boost confidence, and improve performance in high-pressure situations. Praised by The New York Times as "a must-read for anyone looking to achieve their personal best," its influence lies in making the science of presence accessible and reframing confidence as a behavior that can be cultivated, rather than an innate trait. This book is included in Books Recommended by ***WOBI World Business Forum Speakers That Changed the World of Management*** for its practical impact on how leaders show up, decide, and perform when it matters most.



About the Author

A game-changing Social Psychologist, former Professor at Harvard Business School and bestselling author, Amy Cuddy is recognised as a leading authority on the behavioral science of power, presence, and prejudice. As a Harvard Lecturer, in 2018 she won the Excellence in Teaching award.

What Presence Is (and Isn't)

> *"We know it when we feel it, and we know it when we see it, but presence is hard to define. On the other hand, most of us are quite good at describing the lack of it."*

Cuddy defines presence as: *"The state of being attuned to and able to comfortably express our true thoughts, feelings, values, and potential."* It's not permanent. It "comes and goes"—a moment-to-moment state that can be strengthened through small "self-nudges" in body language and mindset.

Presence is **the difference between *being there* and *showing up***. It's what happens when you enter a high-stakes moment with less dread and more grounded energy—focused on doing your best, not on chasing a perfect outcome.

Not an extrovert-only trait

Presence has nothing to do with extroversion. Introverts can demonstrate it just as strongly, and research suggests they often bring strengths that support leadership and entrepreneurship: sustained focus, resistance to decision-making biases, less need for external validation, and strong listening and synthesis.

Synchrony is the signature

Presence requires alignment—"synchrony"—between what you think and feel and how you express it. When we're inauthentic, verbal and nonverbal behavior misalign: expressions don't match words, posture falls out of sync with voice, and the whole message becomes noise.

One key insight: when we over-manage the words, we lose track of the body—throwing ourselves out of synchrony. When we stop controlling every detail, "the gestalt comes together."

Presence is legible

In an analysis of 185 venture capital presentations, the strongest predictors of who received funding weren't only about the content. They were confidence, comfort level, and passionate enthusiasm—signals that the presenter truly believed in the idea and their ability to execute it.

Believing and Owning Your Story

> *"But here's a question: What is the authentic self? What exactly does it mean to be true to yourself?"*

Presence starts with how you understand yourself — and how you tell your story to yourself.

What the self is:

1. Multifaceted, not singular;
2. Expressed through our thoughts, feelings, values, and behaviors; and
3. Dynamic and flexible, not static.

It responds to situations in a way that allows growth — not by changing core values, but by choosing which values and traits to make visible in a given role.

Authentic true self vs. authentic best self

Not everything "true" about us should be amplified. Some parts are destructive; some are private; others we hide out of undeserved shame. The goal is to **identify and bring forward the best parts of ourselves** — the version that supports performance, integrity, and connection.

Express it — don't just find it

Finding your authentic best self isn't enough. You have to figure out how to express it. When people bring their unique qualities to their jobs, they're happier and perform better. And when you find, believe, express, and engage your authentic best self—especially right before your biggest challenges—you reduce anxiety about social rejection, increase openness to others, and become fully present.

Preparation: from content to mindset

Preparation matters — but not as a memorized script. It's about having easier cognitive access to what you know, so you can focus on what's happening, not what you fear might happen. And at some point, you'll also need to shift from **what you'll say to how you'll say it**.

Presence invites presence

"It seems that when you become present, you allow others to be present. Presence doesn't make you dominant in an alpha sense; it actually allows you to hear other people."

Stop Preaching, Start Listening: How Presence Begets Presence

> *"Sometimes we express ourselves most eloquently by not expressing anything—by allowing our presence, unexplained and unembellished, to speak for itself."*

Presence with others starts with something simple: showing up — literally, physically. It's not just what we say; it's how we approach the people we want to connect with and influence.

Warmth vs. competence (and why we get it wrong)

We often size people up fast and assume they're either more warm or more competent — not both. Because competence feels easier to "prove" (résumé, record, scores), we tend to prioritize looking strong and in control. But leadership research shows the risk: the trait most associated with executive failure is an insensitive, abrasive, or bullying style — the opposite of warmth and trustworthiness.

Why we talk instead of listen

Cuddy names a blunt reason it's hard to listen: when we meet someone new, we fear we won't be taken seriously — that we'll seem "less than." Therefore, we talk first to take charge, prove ourselves, set the agenda, and keep control.

But giving up control is scary. It's stepping into the unknown. "Who does that? Only the foolish. Or the **brave**."

Real listening requires presence

Listening is crucial to presence — and it demands the same things presence demands: a sincere desire to understand, the ability to suspend judgment, and the discipline not to respond defensively (even when we're frustrated, impatient, bored, threatened, or anxious).

What changes when you stop preaching and start listening

- ***People trust you**, which makes deep influence possible.*
- ***You gain useful information**, enabling easier problem-solving.*
- ***You stop seeing stereotypes** and move from "us vs. them" to simply "us."*
- ***Solutions stick**, because people support what they help create — and they accept outcomes more when the process feels fair ("procedurally just").*
- ***Listening becomes reciprocal**: "When people feel heard, they are more willing to listen."*

I Don't Deserve to Be Here

Impostorism isn't simple stage fright. It's the belief that you didn't earn your place — and that sooner or later you'll be exposed.

"Everyone wants to be Cary Grant. Even I want to be Cary Grant." — Cary Grant

Why it kills presence

Presence requires being in tune with your true feelings, beliefs, abilities, and values. Impostorism does the opposite: it triggers overthinking and second-guessing, makes you fixate on how others are judging you, and scatters your attention away from what's happening now — suffocating presence right when you need it most.

"Impostorism steals our power and suffocates our presence. If even you don't believe you should be here, how will you convince anybody else?"

It hits everyone — and success doesn't cure it

It may show up differently, but (contrary to popular belief) impostorism afflicts men and women equally. And the cruel irony is that achievements don't stamp it out — success can make it worse. When we feel like impostors, we credit wins to luck, distance ourselves from our strengths, and exaggerate failures.

The way through

You may not eliminate impostor fears forever. The good news is that with awareness, communication, and a smarter understanding of how they work, they become easier to shrug off.

How Powerlessness Shackles the Self (and How Power Sets It Free)

Cuddy draws a sharp distinction between **social power** and **personal power.**

- **Social power**: the ability to influence or control others' behavior; it's tied to disproportionate control over valued resources.
- **Personal power**: access to "limitless inner resources" (skills, values, true personality, boldest self) that make us more open, optimistic, and risk tolerant, which helps us notice and act on opportunities.

Why powerlessness blocks presence

Feeling powerless increases anxiety — and that anxiety undermines executive functions: reasoning, task flexibility, and attention control (exactly what you need in challenging moments).

Powerlessness makes us self-absorbed: anxious people "can't get out of their own heads" to see another person's point of view. Anxiety and self-focus feed each other. It also intensifies the spotlight effect — the bias that makes us think people are paying more attention to us than they really are, usually in a negative way.

And it doesn't end when the moment is over: the more anxious and self-focused we are during an interaction, the more we ruminate afterward ("post-event processing"). Worse, that rumination is built on a flawed memory — because anxiety warps what we actually registered.

What feeling powerful changes

Cuddy frames multiple benefits of power: it can protect us from anxiety, connect us, liberate our thinking, synchronize us, and incite action — making our actions more effective. She also notes that having real-world power seems to offer protection from anxiety.



What feeling powerful changes

See how presence and personal power transform your performance—watch Amy Cuddy reveal her breakthrough insights from the World Business Forum. Your next level starts here!



The Language of the Body: From Power to Presence

> *"When we feel powerful, we make ourselves bigger."*

Power doesn't only expand the mind — it expands the body. Across channels like posture, gaze, gestures, walking style, and vocal cues, **powerful** nonverbal behavior tends to be more expansive, while **powerless** behavior makes us smaller.

What power looks like (and sounds like)

- Powerful walking is **expansive**: more arm movement, longer stride, more head movement.
- Powerless walking is restricted: little arm movement, shorter stride, stationary head.
- Powerful people initiate speech more, **talk more**, **make more eye contact**, speak more slowly, and pause without rushing — they feel entitled to the time they're using.
- When we feel powerless, we shorten, slouch, collapse, and restrict — and observers read that as powerlessness and fear.

Learned vs. hardwired

Cuddy raises the question of whether body language is culturally learned or hardwired, noting that spontaneous expressions of pride appear to be universal.

Gender, stereotypes, and power

Men often use more expansive body language than women — but many of the differences we observe are grounded in power differences, amplified by stereotyping and confirmation bias, rather than biology alone.

The point isn't domination

"Should we just dominate everybody with our body language?" No. The goal is to look confident and relaxed — intimacy, not intimidation. And norms vary across cultures, so reading context matters.

The Language of the Body: From Power to Presence

Power posing (what it changes)

"The body shapes the mind, and the mind shapes behavior."

By adopting expansive, open postures,
we tend to feel more powerful, confident, and assertive, and less stressed and anxious—often becoming happier and more optimistic, even at a less conscious level.

Posture shapes self-concept (and performance)

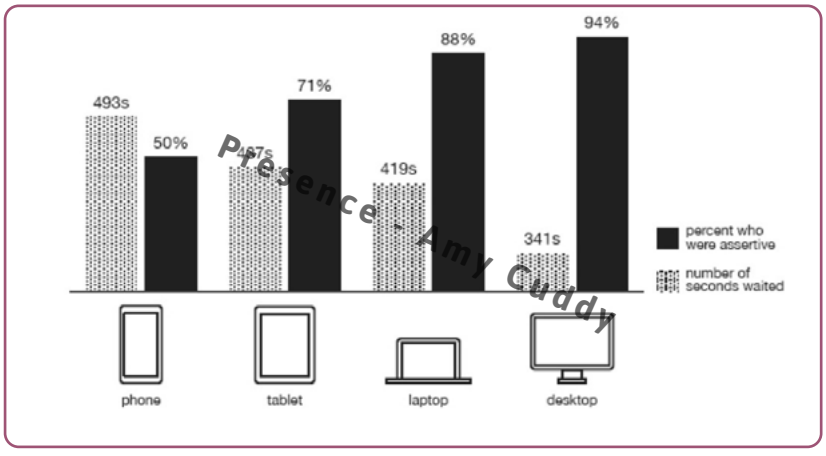
Posture doesn't just change how we feel; it shapes how we think about ourselves—our self-descriptions, and how certain we feel about them. Brief powerless poses can increase negative self-thoughts and dull drive and creativity; neutral postures keep attention on the task (in the moment). Upright posture also makes it easier to think empowering thoughts and believe in the traits you list.





Tech + "iPosture" (a hidden power drain)

Devices already pull attention away from the moment—but they can also pull the body into shrunken, inward postures. The smaller the device, the more we contract; the more time we spend contracted, the more powerless we may feel (and the more assertive behavior shifts with bigger devices).



How to Pose for Presence

Power posing is most useful before situations that trigger powerless body language—new environments, meeting new people, speaking a nonnative language, asking for help, ending relationships, quitting a job, or giving/receiving critical feedback. The key is to notice what triggers you, so you know when to use it.

"Sit up straight." — Your grandmother

Prepare with Big Poses (before the moment)

Use big poses privately right before a challenge: taking up space tells you "you've got this," freeing you to bring your boldest, most authentic self.

Practical ideas

Morning poses, private corners in public spaces (elevator/stall/stairwell), avoid hunching in waiting rooms, or even "pose mentally" (superhero in your own thought bubble). If you must sit, open the chest/shoulders by clasping hands behind the chair.

Present with Good Posture (during the moment)

High-power poses during interactions can backfire. Instead, hold strong, upright, open posture:

- Shoulders back, chest open; breathe slowly and deeply
- Chin level; feet grounded
- Move with intention (steps + pause; don't pace)
- Use props to prevent collapsing
- Adopt open gestures (palms up signals trust)
- Avoid "penguin arms"
- Take up temporal space: slow down, pause, let your voice drop to its natural level
- If you make a mistake, don't collapse inward — "unfurl, and power up"

Mind posture all day

Build tiny supports: recognize your "shrink" triggers, set reminders, organize spaces to encourage expansion, combine posture with routines, stretch, walk, try standing more, do "walking meetings," and seize chances to expand (gym, yoga, dance).

Self-Nudging: How Tiny Tweaks Lead to Big Changes

Cuddy reframes change as **small, repeatable nudges**—not big reinventions. Tiny tweaks work because they're low-cost, require minimal commitment, and can reshape behavior (and then attitudes) over time.

The core move: slow down

In high-pressure moments, doing nothing can be doing something: it reduces threat, restores "fully functioning cognitive machinery" (working memory, clarity, perspective), and often works better than hasty "fixing."

Why nudges stick

Early nudge researchers described them as "nano-sized investments" that lead to "medium-sized gains." Nudges work through choice architecture and psychological shortcuts—and because behavior can shape attitudes, not only the other way around.

How small wins become lasting change

Your behavior reinforces itself: once you've acted with courage or competence, you can recall it next time ("I've done this before"). Agency, self-efficacy, and deservingness grow. Nonverbal interventions (deep breathing, smiling, sitting up straight, power posing) can reduce the "ever-calculating… cauldron" of self-evaluation in the moment. Physiological changes can reinforce the new behavior, too.

Reinforcement is social, not just personal

Nonverbal expression is a two-way conversation: your signals prompt responses, which reinforce impressions of you—and of yourself—shaping how you behave next time.

Why big self-change plans fail

Resolutions are often too ambitious, too distant, too negative, and can undermine intrinsic motivation.

A powerful reframe

By changing the meaning of what you feel—nudging from anxiety to excitement—you shift orientation and access the resources needed under pressure: turning stage fright into stage presence.

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